

El Chichón

Location The state of Chiapas, southern Mexico

Until late March 1982, El Chichón was thought to be an extinct volcano, with no eruption known for over 600 years. Then, in the space of a few days, three huge eruptions pumped millions of tonnes of gas and ash into the

atmosphere, destroying nine villages and killing 2,000 people. The magma was very rich in sulfur, and sulfuric acid droplets forming in the stratosphere produced brilliant sunsets around the globe. A new crater was formed, 0.6 mile (1 km) across, which is now filled with an acidic lake. The peak of the volcano, which has been quiet ever since, is 3,772 ft (1,150 m) above sea level.

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Central and South America

Mount Pelée

Location Martinique in the Lesser Antilles, Caribbean Sea

Pelée is a stratovolcano (composite volcano) in the Antilles island arc. After many years of inactivity, in 1902 it produced the most devastating eruption of the 20th century in terms of casualties. A series of pyroclastic clouds swept down its slopes to destroy the city of Saint-Pierre, killing about 30,000 people. The Peléan type of eruption, characterized by explosive

emissions of ash, gas, and pyroclastic flows, is named after this volcano.

Arenal

Location Northwest Costa Rica, Central America

Arenal is Costa Rica's youngest and most active volcano. Situated over an active subduction zone where the Cocos Plate pushes beneath the Caribbean Plate, this stratovolcano was dormant for hundreds of years before July 1968, when an unexpected and violent eruption destroyed three small towns. Rocks weighing several tons were blasted more than 0.6 mile (1 km) away. Seven

▼ A LAVA FOUNTAIN AT ARENAL

